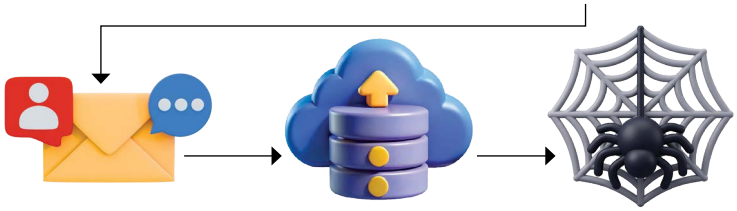
## HOW DATA GETS LEAKED

**1 Hackers exploit a weak server, an employee's compromised corporate email account or a stolen remote access token**



**2 Once inside the network, the external attacker or malicious insider scans internal databases, directories and file servers to locate customers' personal information**



**3 The data is then compiled and may be exfiltrated via personal email, unauthorised USB drives or screen captures**

**4 The stolen data is then transferred to an external command-and-control server or a cloud repository controlled by the hacker**

**5 It is then offered for sale on dark web channels, where scammers purchase it to carry out targeted phishing, SIM-swapping or financial fraud**

## UNDER CYBERATTACK

*Recent incidents that have put banking data security under scrutiny*

**Nov. 2021:** Cybersecurity firm CyberX9 alleges that a vulnerability in a Punjab National Bank server had potentially exposed the personal and financial information of around 180 million customers for nearly seven months. PNB denies the charge

**Jan. 2025:** The BASHE ransomware and cyber extortion group claims to have breached ICICI Bank and threatens to release data unless a ransom is paid. ICICI Bank does not publicly confirm the alleged breach and is later penalised by the RBI

**Jul. 27, 2026:** Bank of Baroda discloses a cybersecurity incident involving business email compromise

**Oct. 21, 2026:** SBI says the Defence Cyber Agency, its threat intelligence provider, and the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) alerted it on October 18 regarding suspected customer data exposure

**"We wish to submit that this [the customer data exposure] does not have any material impact on the bank's core business operations, financial performance or business continuity"**

**–SBI STATEMENT**

hit the State Bank of India (SBI), India's largest commercial bank, which has around 530 million customers. On October 21, the lender said that the Defence Cyber Agency, its threat intelligence provider, and the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) had, on October 18, alerted it regarding suspected customer data exposure. During the preliminary analysis of around 375,000 records available on the dark web—a small, hidden part of the internet that is not indexed by standard search engines like Google and requires specialised software to access—the bank identified 3,897 customer records containing "personally identifiable information". The information included names, mobile phone numbers, dates of birth, email and residential addresses, customer identification details and metadata associated with loan records, among others. It may not end with just those 3,897 records, because the bank is still investigating both the source as well as the extent of the exposure. "We wish to submit that this does not have any material impact on the bank's core business operations, financial performance or business continuity," SBI said in its statement. "The bank's core business functions continue to operate normally without disruptions."

**MORE CYBERATTACKS ARE CARRIED OUT TODAY WITHOUT USING ANY MALWARE, BUT BY SIMPLY TRICKING PEOPLE INTO SHARING THEIR LOGIN NAMES, PASSWORDS OR OTPs**